Saving (Bachat): a private, chat-first AI savings agent

Technical Documentation: 2026 FinTechathon International Track, Topic A (Personal Finance Assistant)

Team ACE 2.0

1. Summary

Saving (working name *Bachat*, Urdu for “savings”) is an AI agent that acts as a personal finance assistant for people in Pakistan. A user talks to it, in English or Roman Urdu and by text or voice. It learns their banks, cards, income and saving goals through conversation. It then reads their bank-alert emails and turns them into categorised spending. It works out how much they can save, finds the card discounts they can use at the places they actually spend, and credits every discount they use to a saving goal. It messages them first when something matters, including when the app is closed.

Track and topic. International Track, **Topic A: Personal Finance Assistant** (“smart budgeting, bill analysis, spending insights, actionable recommendations based on the user’s income and expenses”).

Design position. The agent is a financial *participant* that decides and acts inside the user’s ledger: it creates goals, splits income between them, records transactions, offers deals and closes the loop when a deal is used. It has **no authority over real money**. It cannot initiate payments or transfers, and it holds read-only access to email. We chose this deliberately: the safest permission tier for a consumer finance agent is one where the worst possible mistake is a wrong number on a screen, not a wrong payment.

2. Problem and target user

Most Pakistani salaried users hold several accounts (a bank, a mobile wallet, a digital bank) and several cards. They have no single view of their money. The bank sends an SMS or email for every transaction, but nothing turns those alerts into a budget. Card discounts are plentiful (banks run hundreds of merchant promotions) but are scattered across bank websites and social pages, tied to a specific card network and tier, and expire quickly. People miss them and never see the savings.

Existing budgeting apps assume a US-style open-banking API, manual entry, or a form-heavy setup. None of those fit a market where bank data arrives as email alerts and where the card and tier you hold decide which discount applies.

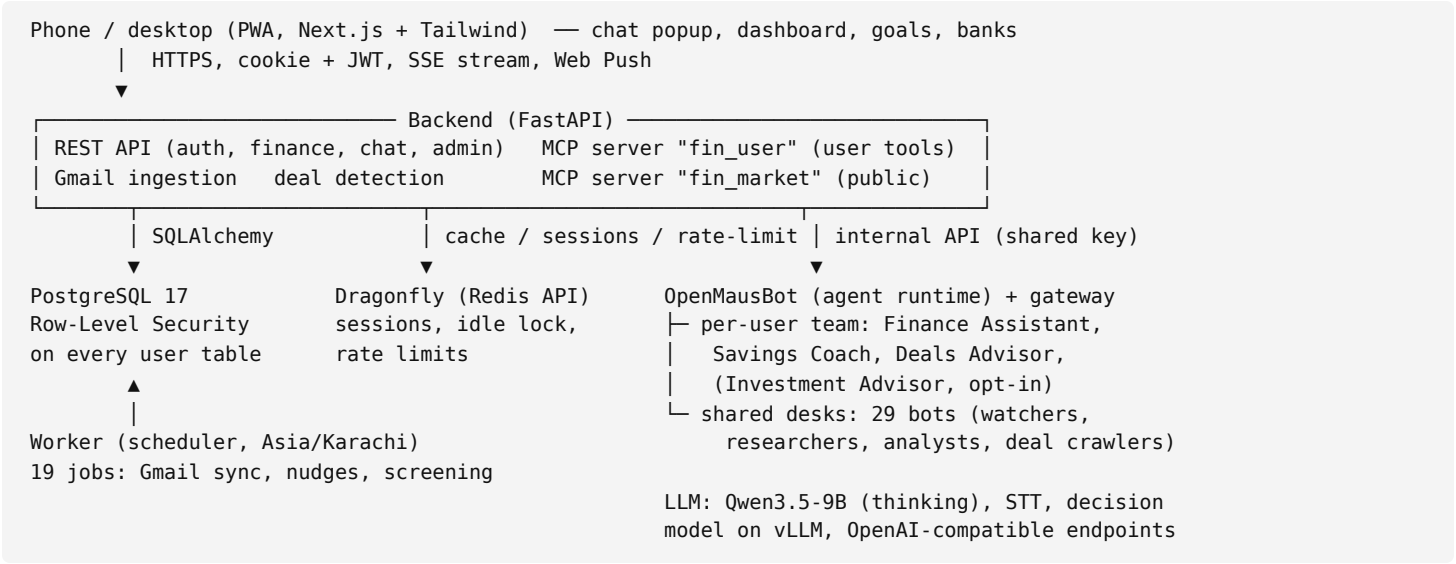
Our user is a salaried or self-employed person with a phone as the main device, who wants to save toward concrete goals (“a car in 6 months on Rs. 100,000 a month”) without becoming a spreadsheet user.

3. What the agent does (task completion)

Capability	What happens	Where in the code
Chat-based onboarding	No forms. The Finance Assistant collects banks, the exact card (“Visa Gold debit, Meezan”), income and pay day, goals, savings rule, sadqah preference and optional investing opt-in, one topic per message, in any order.	`ai-ml/prompts/finance_assistant/SOUL.md`, `backend/app/mcp/user_server.py`
Card validation	Cards are saved only if they exist in a catalogue of 163 real cards across 23 banks and wallets. A near miss returns `did_you_mean` and asks the user to confirm. No card digits, CVV, PIN or OTP are ever stored.	`backend/app/seed/cards.py`, `services/cards.py`
Transaction intake	Bank-alert emails are read from Gmail (read-only) every 5 minutes. A regex parser handles known bank formats; an LLM parse is the fallback. Users can also tell the chat (“I spent 2,000 at Imtiaz”).	`services/gmail.py`, `services/categorize.py`
Spending insight	Transactions are categorised (food, grocery, fuel, medicine, utilities and so on). The dashboard shows totals, a per-bank breakdown, expendable vs saved money and a per-goal progress view.	`services/finance.py`, `api/finance.py`
Savings planning	Savings rule: percentage of income, fixed amount, or whatever is left at month end. Several goals are split equally, by priority, by custom weights or by deadline. A preview shows what each rule means, and the agent says so honestly when a goal is unrealistic. Capped goals redistribute overflow, and the split always conserves money (unit-tested).	`services/finance.py`, `tests/test_finance.py`
Deal discovery and capture	A crawler team collects bank and merchant offers into a shared database, with validity dates, weekdays, card requirements and caps. A per-user Deals Advisor matches them to the user’s cards and favourite places and records an offer with `offer_deal`.	`ai-ml/prompts/deals_*`, `services/deals.py`
Automatic deal-use detection	When a debit alert arrives, plain code (no LLM) checks it against the deals the person was offered: same merchant, inside the dates and weekdays, matching card, over the minimum spend. A match credits the saving to their goal and sends “Great, you just saved Rs. X”. Each offer and each transaction can count only once.	`services/deal_detect.py`, `tests/test_deal_detect.py`

Capability	What happens	Where in the code
Proactive nudges	Weekly savings summary (Fri), overspend alert when a day exceeds 1.8x the daily budget, month-end leftover sweep into goals, optional sadqah reminders, a Sunday check-in from the agent. They arrive as push notifications (Web Push) even with the app closed.	`worker.py`, `services/jobs.py`, `services/notify.py`
Memory and adaptation	“I got an increment”, “I closed my card”: the agent updates the structured data and stores a fact that supersedes the old one, so later advice changes.	`remember_fact` / `forget_fact` tools
Voice	Voice notes are transcribed to editable text in English or Roman Urdu (Urdu script on request).	`core/llm.py`, `frontend/src/lib/wav.ts`
Optional investment board	Opt-in only, behind a disclaimer the user must accept. Five desks (gold and silver, PSX, foreign stocks, crypto, Pakistani real estate) publish signals and research; the per-user Investment Advisor explains them.	`ai-ml/prompts/*_{researcher,analyst,watcher}`

4. System architecture



Services (Docker Compose for development, Railway for production, one `Dockerfile` per folder, one root `.env`):

Service	Role
`frontend`	Installable PWA, mobile-first and responsive to desktop. Sign-up, sign-in, password reset, email connection, dashboard, goal detail, bank detail, chat widget. Idle lock and fingerprint / face unlock (WebAuthn passkeys).
`backend`	FastAPI API plus the two MCP tool servers and the Alembic migrations.

Service	Role
`worker`	The only scheduler. Runs jobs and wakes the agents. Exactly one replica.
`omb`	OpenMausBot agent runtime plus the gateway that bridges it to the backend.
`postgres`, `dragonfly`	Data, and sessions / rate limits.

4.1 Agent design

- **Teams.** Each user gets a private team of 3 to 4 agents in a private chat room: *Finance Assistant* (lead, onboarding, everyday questions), *Savings Coach* (budget and habits), *Deals Advisor* and, if opted in, *Investment Advisor*. Every agent's behaviour is a Markdown prompt in `ai-ml/prompts/<agent>/SOUL.md`. Agents are created at first start and re-applied only when their prompt hash changes.
- **Decision model.** A small model routes each message to the right advisor, and the Finance Assistant answers by default.
- **Tools, not free text.** Agents change state only by calling typed tools (`create_goal`, `add_card`, `record_transaction`, `move_to_savings`, `offer_deal`, `avail_deal`, …). The tools validate inputs, enforce business rules (for example the card catalogue) and write the ledger. The LLM never writes SQL or amounts directly.
- **Deterministic core, LLM at the edges.** Money maths (goal splits, savings rules, discount value, redemption matching) is ordinary tested Python. The LLM handles language, onboarding dialogue, parsing unfamiliar alert formats and judging merchants. This keeps the numbers auditable and the failure modes bounded.
- **Shared desks vs private teams.** Public-data desks (market watchers, researchers, deal crawlers) are scheduled, keep their own memory and write to shared tables. Per-user agents have no memory except their own private room. OpenMausBot copies recent activity from a bot's other chats into its prompt, so a shared bot serving several users would leak between them; we therefore clone one private bot set per user rather than share bots.

4.2 Data model (summary)

User-owned tables: `users`, `user_profiles`, `bank_accounts`, `cards`, `goals`, `savings_ledger`, `transactions`, `deal_offers`, `deal_redemptions`, `user_facts`, `email_connections`, `chat_rooms`, `chat_messages`, `push_subscriptions`, `webauthn_credentials`, `notifications`. Shared reference tables: `banks`, `card_products`, `categories`, `merchants`, `deals`, `market_signals`, `research_notes`, `watch_clusters`, `plans` (the schema is ready for billing later). System tables: `agent_registry`, `audit_log`.

5. Security and compliance (30% of the score)

5.1 Permission tiers

Tier	Who / what	Can do	Cannot do
T0: public	Anonymous visitor	Sign up (OTP-verified email), sign in, reset password	Anything else
T1: user	Signed-in person	Read and write **only their own** rows; chat with their own agents	See any other user; admin pages

Tier	Who / what	Can do	Cannot do
T2: user's agents	The 3 to 4 private bots	Call the `fin_user` tool set (about 32 tools, vs 72 offered by default) with the room's member key	Create bots or rooms, run commands, read other chats, move real money
T3: shared desk agents	29 market and deal bots	Call the `fin_market` tool set over public data and shared tables	See any user id, balance or transaction
T4: admin	Admin accounts (separate from users; they have no finances or chat)	Manage users, deals, agents, plans; every action is written to `audit_log`	Read a user's private chat as a user
T5: system	Worker and gateway	Background jobs, migrations	Reachable from outside; authenticated with a shared internal key

No tier can initiate a payment, transfer or any write to a bank. The only "move to savings" is a ledger entry in our own database. The only external credential held for a user is a read-only Gmail token.

5.2 Controls

- **Row-Level Security in the database, not just the API.** Every user-owned table has `ENABLE` and `FORCE ROW LEVEL SECURITY` with a policy keyed on `app.user_id`. Each request opens a transaction that sets the role and user id (`scoped_session`). A bug in application code, or a tool call from a confused agent, still cannot read another user's rows. We verified this directly in Postgres. Regular users cannot touch global tables (read-only for them); only admin or system roles can write.
- **Agent isolation.** OpenMausBot gives MCP servers no caller identity, so each tool takes a random `member_key` that lives only in that user's private room bulletin and resolves to exactly one user. Keys are stored hashed and encrypted. Calls are rate-limited (600 per minute per key; invalid keys are throttled and delayed).
- **Least-privilege tools per agent.** Allow-lists are set per bot in `ai-ml/gateway/teams.py`.
- **Authentication.** Argon2 password hashing; short-lived JWT access token plus a rotating refresh token held in a server-side session; sign-up needs an emailed OTP; passkeys (fingerprint / face) via WebAuthn.
- **Bank-app-style idle lock.** After inactivity the session is *locked*: the API answers 423 until the user re-enters a password or uses a passkey. Unlock attempts are limited.
- **Abuse limits.** Rate limits on sign-up (10 per hour per IP), OTP verify, resend, sign-in (8 per 15 minutes per IP and email), password reset, unlock and tool calls.
- **Data minimisation.** Card numbers, CVV, PIN and OTP are never requested or stored. Only network, tier and debit/credit are kept. If a user types digits, the agent tells them not to share and does not store them. Gmail access is `gmail.readonly`, and only bank-alert messages are parsed. Gmail tokens are encrypted at rest (Fernet).
- **Privacy boundary for third-party models.** User chats, advisors and bank-email parsing run only on the **self-hosted** model. The shared desks may be pointed at a third-party LLM because they handle public data only. The one user-derived input they receive is merchant names, and every new merchant is first screened by the self-hosted model so a private payee ("Transfer to Ali Khan") is marked `personal` and never reaches a shared bot. The screening **fails closed**: if the model is offline the merchant stays hidden.
- **Secrets.** One root `.env` (git-ignored). The agents container receives only the 16 variables it needs, so JWT, encryption, SMTP, OAuth and database-owner secrets never reach it.
- **Auditability.** Admin actions are logged. Each deal saving, ledger entry and transaction records its source (`gmail`, `chat`, `deal`).

5.3 Compliance and responsible AI

- The agent states that it is **not a licensed financial advisor** and gives no guarantees. The investment board is opt-in; the user must see and explicitly accept the disclaimer before it is enabled, and the tool refuses without `disclaimer_accepted`.
- Advice is explainable: figures come from the user's own data via tools, and recommendations quote the numbers behind them. The agent is told never to invent balances, goals or deals.
- Islamic-finance aware (halal / riba-free options, sadqah) without being preachy.
- Account deletion removes the user's rows (cascade) and their agents and room in the runtime; failed runtime cleanups are retried.

5.4 Known risks and limitations (self-assessment)

We list these openly because the Security self-assessment asks for them.

#	Risk	Status / mitigation
1	**Prompt injection** through email text or merchant names could try to steer an agent.	Agents can only call a small typed tool set scoped to one user; no payment tool exists; money rules live in code. Residual risk: it could push wrong ledger entries for that user. Planned: confirmation step for large manual entries.
2	**Member key in a prompt.** A key shown to an LLM could in theory be repeated in chat.	Keys identify only the user's own room and are never shown to the user by instruction; the room is the user's own. Planned: per-call signed tokens if the runtime adds caller identity.
3	**Small-model reliability** (Qwen3.5-9B tool calling and onboarding quality) is not yet measured at scale.	Deterministic maths and validation in tools; evaluation set planned (see section 8).
4	**Bank-alert parsing** covers known formats; others fall back to the LLM and could mis-parse.	Old alerts never override a stated balance; parse failures are logged; the user can correct by chat.
5	**Deal detection** depends on merchant-name matching ("KFC" vs "KFC Pakistan") and assumes the debited amount is after discount.	Reported as "about Rs. X"; only offered deals are tracked; credit-card deals stay manual.
6	**Scheduled desk runs** (watchers, researchers, crawlers) are verified to the trigger call but not yet over a full cycle with the production model.	Admin -> Agents shows status and last error per agent.
7	**No MFA** beyond the passkey option; no device-binding.	Idle lock plus passkeys; MFA is planned.
8	**Demo data migration** (`0002_demo_data`) exists for evaluation.	Skipped when `ENVIRONMENT=production`; removal is documented.
9	**OpenMausBot image** is pinned to `latest` in the Dockerfile.	To be pinned to a release tag before production.

#	Risk	Status / mitigation
10	**Third-party data** (market prices, scraped PSX data, deal pages) may be wrong or stale.	Shown as signals with sources and a disclaimer; investment feature is opt-in.

6. Innovation and interaction (30% of the score)

1. **Built for how Pakistan's banking data actually arrives.** Instead of requiring an open-banking API that does not exist there, the agent ingests the bank-alert emails people already receive, and in doing so reconstructs a live ledger.
2. **Card-aware deals with automatic proof of saving.** The card catalogue turns "any discount" into "a discount you can use with the card in your wallet". Detection then closes the loop with no LLM and no user effort: the saved amount goes straight into their goal. We are not aware of another consumer app that credits a discount to a saving goal automatically.
3. **Privacy architecture for agents.** Database-level RLS plus per-user agent rooms plus a split between a self-hosted model (private data) and an optional third-party model (public data only), with a fail-closed merchant screen between them.
4. **Chat as the whole interface.** Onboarding, updates, voice, deal capture and goal changes all happen in conversation. Language follows the user (English, Roman Urdu or Urdu script) and is never asked.
5. **Proactive, bank-grade feel.** Push messages with the app closed, an idle lock, and fingerprint or face unlock, in a PWA that installs on a home screen.
6. **Agent team design.** Three or four specialised private agents plus a routing model, with deterministic financial maths underneath.

7. Execution evidence and how to reproduce

This is a **non-on-chain topic**, so evidence is simulated-account and sandbox operation logs plus a demo video.

- **Run it:** `cp .env.example .env`, fill secrets, `docker compose up -d --build`. Web app at `http://localhost:3000`, API docs at `/api/docs`, gateway health at `:8790/health`.
- **Demo accounts** (temporary migration): user *Osama* `demo@bachat.pk` / `demo12345`; admin `admin@bachat.pk` / `admin12345`.
- **Simulated bank alerts:** the navbar **Test bank email** button injects realistic credit and debit alerts that pass through the real parser, categoriser, savings split and deal-detection code.
- **Tests:** `cd backend && uv run pytest`. Covers goal-split conservation, capped-goal redistribution, deadline weighting, alert parsing, balance protection against stale alerts, card catalogue enforcement, deal-redemption rules and merchant screening.
- **Evidence to attach:** (1) the onboarding chat transcript, (2) sandbox logs of a salary credit split into goals, a KFC / PSO spend categorised, and a deal offered then auto-detected as used, (3) the Admin -> Agents screen, (4) a Postgres session showing RLS denying cross-user reads, (5) the demo video.

8. Roadmap before and after the final

- Measure Qwen3.5-9B on a fixed evaluation set (onboarding completion, correct tool arguments, Roman Urdu quality); publish the scores.
- Confirm a full scheduled cycle on the production model.

- Add a confirmation step for large manual entries; add MFA.
- Add more banks' alert formats; reduce LLM-parse fallbacks.
- Billing (schema ready), shared goals for families, and Raast-based payments as a separate, explicit, user-approved permission tier. It is not enabled today.

9. Technology stack

Python 3.12, FastAPI, SQLAlchemy and Alembic; PostgreSQL 17; Dragonfly (Redis API); Next.js with Tailwind (PWA, service worker, Web Push, WebAuthn); OpenMausBot as the agent runtime; Qwen3.5-9B (thinking), Qwen3-ASR and a decision model on vLLM / llama.cpp behind OpenAI-compatible endpoints; Docker Compose for development and Railway for production. Open-source components are used under their own licences.